Sessions

By Chris Silver

DR. RUBENSTEIN: **(Pgs 3-16)** Welcome to the team, Sara! I am so delighted that you've decided to join us here at Sunnyside Community Clinic.

SARA: Thank you, Dr. Rubinstein. It's really an honor to be here.

DR. RUBENSTEIN: This is a big step, Sara. Leaving the comforting nest of school and entering the cold, vile, traumatizing, hopeless, demoralizing, perverse, shocking, overwhelming, sordid, inhumane, disgusting world of actually being a therapist and having patients. I have no idea why on earth anyone would want to do it. Are you nervous? You should be.

INTRODUCTION

Many therapists and counselors are well-meaning, intelligent, caring, capable, competent professionals with the best of intentions. But the system they're working in? The magnitude of the problems they confront? In many cases, let's just say they're up against some extremely "interesting" challenges. It can be rugged terrain. Fasten your seatbelt, Sara . . . you are in for one wild ride.

Sessions by Chris Silver

DR. RUBENSTEIN: I have just a few words of advice, Sara. So listen carefully. *(Sara takes out her notebook and begins writing.)* Don't ever tell a patient that they're your first, Don't ever say, "I'm sorry," And by God, young lady, don't ever let a patient see you sweat! You're going to do just fine!

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SARA: What brings you in today, Mrs. Weatherbottom?

MRS W: My husband and I have been married 57 years.

SARA: I see. Can you tell me a little more about that, Mrs. Weatherbottom?

MRS W: I can. We've been married 57 years, and, frankly, I'm tired of his shit.

SARA: Beg pardon?

MRS W: That's an example of standing up for myself, telling it like it is. I'm not going to

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stand for his crap anymore. My last therapist told me that it was important for me to be more direct.

SARA: I see. And what is it exactly that's troubling you about your husband, Mrs. Weatherbottom?

MRS W: What is it with you people and repeating my name every time you speak to me? I'm 83, not senile! He has a coffee cup problem.

SARA: A coffee cup problem, Mrs. W. . . ?

MRS W: That's what I said, yes. I have been asking Mr. Weatherbottom for the last 57 years to rinse out his cup after he has his morning coffee. And for the last 57 years he has failed to do so. What did I find this morning, after he left for his morning constitutional? That's right. The disgusting, foul remnants of his morning coffee. It repulses me.

SARA: I hear that you have some very strong feelings about this.

MRS W: I do. And my last therapist recommended that I take a stand. So I have.

SARA: Being assertive is very important, Mrs. Weatherbottom. How is your husband responding to the new you?

MRS W: I'm not sure.

SARA: What do you mean?

MRS W: Well, he hasn't returned from his morning constitutional.

SARA: I'm not sure that I follow.

MRS W: Oh, good heavens. I've been putting a few drops of rat poison in Mr. Weatherbottom's coffee for the past few months, dear.

SARA: You what? You've been poisoning your husband?

MRS W: Oh, don't get all goody-two-shoes on me, sweetie. You haven't had to live with that revolting coffee cup for the last 57 years.

SARA: I see. I'm sorry-

DR. RUBENSTEIN: "Don't ever tell a patient that you 're sorry .. "

MRS W: According to my internet research, the poison should have been gradually

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building up in his system, until, well, until I won't have to worry about the coffee cup any longer!

SARA: I, oh, well, you're my first...

DR. RUBENSTEIN: "Don't ever tell a patient they're your first . . . "

SARA: Oh, crap. *(sweating profusely)* Great. Mrs. Weatherbottom, I'm required by law to report any action to harm . . .

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SARA: Helen, Tom, so nice to meet you. What brings you in today?

HELEN: I just don't feel like we're connecting like we used to. It's like the flame has died. The spark has been stamped out.

TOM: Oh, sweetie, I think you're just overreacting. You 're just being a big drama queen about this. Maybe it's a mid-life crisis.

HELEN: I'm 27.

TOM: Well, perhaps we just need to have a spa day. Facials. Get manis, pedis. . . *(to Sara)* What do you think?

SARA: Well, Helen, why don't you share with Tom about the things that have been bothering you.

HELEN: Tom, I just feel like I don't matter as much to you as I used to. It's like you care more about your shoes than you do me!

TOM: *(a horrified gasp.)* Do NOT bring my shoes into this! You love going shoe shopping with me!

HELEN: Tom, you have 200 pairs. It's like you've been in your own world. You don't care about what's important to me anymore. I mean, I love Cher and Madonna as much as anyone, but variety in life is important!

SARA: Oh, good lord.

HELEN: And, I believe in community service, I really do. But I can't take anymore time off of work to travel around the country selling your handmade rainbow lanyards at Pride festivals.

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TOM: You told me that you loved my rainbow lanyards! Especially the beaded ones with the little side fringes.

HELEN: Now, Tom, don't get upset . . . I just think we need a little more "us" time, Tom.

TOM: Us time? Us time? This is feeling very overwhelming for me right now. I need to take some deep breaths.

SARA: Okay, hang on. I don't mean to be presumptive, Helen, but have you considered the possibility that Tom might be g-

HELEN: Greedy? Yes, I have. Tom just seems to care about himself lately.

SARA: No, Helen, not greedy. G-

HELEN: Guilty. Yes, I think that's a good observation. I would imagine that Tom is feeling very guilty about neglecting me, his wife.

TOM: I do not feel guilty, sweetheart! I will not apologize for being fabulous!

SARA: NO! NO! Not greedy! Not guilty! Not gluttonous or gruesome either. GAY! Have you considered the possibility that Tom might be GAY?

HELEN: No. That hasn't occurred to me. *(considers it very seriously)* Hmmm. No. I don't think that's the problem.

TOM: I am definitely not gay, sweetheart. Maybe you're new at this?

SARA: Oh, good grief. *(looks as if she's about to cry)*

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SARA: Yes, what is it?

AMY: I've seen a whole lot of therapists, and I've never heard that opening before. Long day got you down? What are you, new?

SARA: Actually, no, I've been at this for a while now. But, let's talk about you, Amy. *(reading from her file.)* It looks like you were just placed with a new foster family. How is that going for you?

AMY: Not very well.

SARA: That's too bad. Would you like to tell me a little more about that?

AMY: I'm basically like the bad seed.

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SARA: That sounds a little dramatic.

AMY: It's actually an understatement.

SARA: Why don't you share a little more with me about how things have been going at your new placement?

AMY: Well, let's see . . . I made some delicious refreshments for my new foster mommy and daddy and then I served them my tantalizing concoctions accompanied by an original song and dance routine.

SARA: That sounds very. . . spirited of you. How did they like that?

AMY: They hated it. I don't think they liked my smoothies very much . . .

SARA: What gave you that impression?

AMY: Probably something about them screaming and crying while I was serving them. And then there was that part about them calling the police.

SARA: *(getting a bit nervous)* What kind of smoothies did you serve them, Amy?

AMY: My favorite. Strawberry Banana. With a little something extra. Like a protein boost.

SARA: Okay . . .

AMY: Well, you see, there's a perfectly logical explanation . . . I was home doing my homework, when I thought, "what would a fun activity for the bad seed?" And, well, then I saw Whiskers, and well. . . *(during her description, my pantomimes the process and makes the blender and meow sounds)* It was really pretty easy . . . I just put Whiskers in the freezer, for, quite a while . . .

SARA: This isn't happening

AMY: Oh, but it is, then I took a butcher . . .

SARA: Okay . . . okay . . .

AMY: They have a really powerful blender! . . . *(demonic voice)* I told them I was allergic to cats! *(singing and dancing)* "Kitty smoothie! Meow Meow Meow! Kitty Smoothie! . . . Is it true that kids who do bad things to animals often grow up to be serial killers?

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(As SARA reflects on her day, bits and pieces of her clients come back to her, rapid fire, building to a literal crescendo of nuttiness. . . the noise of AMY's blender and the cat's meowing are interspersed throughout the entire sequence.)

MRS W: 57 years of that coffee cup!

TOM: I'm not gay, I'm just fabulous!

DR. RUBENSTEIN: Don't ever say, I'm sorry!

MRS W: You will pay, Mr. Weatherbottom. I warned you.

DR. RUBENSTEIN: Don't every let them see you sweat.

TOM: Just because I have more shoes then Helen does, does not make me G-

AMY: Bad seed, I tell you!

DR. RUBENSTEIN: "Don't ever tell a patient they're your first . . . "

AMY: *(singing)* "Kitty smoothie! Kitty smoothie! Meow meow meow!" *(the sequence builds to an explosive ...*

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SARA: *(utterly exhausted, with nothing left to give)* I'm sure I'm not supposed to tell you this, but I don't care. You're my last patient of the day. What's your problem?

LORI: Um, well, we just had a new baby, Rick and I, and well, she's our first. We're a little overwhelmed. Excited, but overwhelmed. It's a lot, you know? And, we just want to make sure we're communicating about everything and

RICK: And we just thought it would be good to talk to someone.

SARA: Right. Because your baby is possessed by Satan.

LORI: *(nervous laughter)* Oh, you' re funny. No, she's wonderful. She's perfect.

SARA: Okay, the two of you are actually axe-murderers. Oh, no, wait. . . you're axe murderers who each have 700 personalities, and you believe that you're actually aliens from . . . I don't know, Neptune.

RICK: You are really funny. We must be so normal compared to most of the folks who come in here. We're pretty boring. We just want to talk.

SARA: Just talk? Is this a trick?

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AMY: *(singing)* "Kitty smoothie! Kitty Smoothie! Meow Meow Meow!" *(ends with the blender and a loud cat screech)*

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AWARD HISTORY

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